Portside Logistics -- Driver Handbook

Effective for all company and contract drivers operating out of the Chennai, Bengaluru, and Mumbai depots.

1. Welcome and Purpose

This handbook sets the operating rules for every driver working a Portside Logistics route, whether you are a full-time company driver or a contracted owner-operator. It exists so that customers get a consistent experience no matter which depot dispatched the load, and so that every driver knows exactly what is expected before, during, and after a run.

Dispatchers and depot managers use RouteMind, the internal operations assistant, to answer day-to-day questions about routes and shipments. This handbook is one of the source documents RouteMind is allowed to search when a driver or dispatcher asks a policy question.

2. Reporting for Duty

Drivers report to their home depot at the time shown on the weekly roster, not the time the shift technically starts. This gives time for the pre-shift briefing and the vehicle inspection described in the Safety and Compliance Guide.

- Check in with the depot dispatcher and confirm your assigned vehicle and trailer number.
- Attend the pre-shift briefing, which covers route hazards, weather, and any customer notes.
- Complete the pre-trip inspection before leaving the yard.
- Log on to the driver app and confirm your first stop before departure.

3. Hours of Service and Rest Breaks

No driver may exceed 10 hours of driving within a single shift. A mandatory 30-minute break is required after 5 continuous hours behind the wheel, and at least 8 hours of rest are required between the end of one shift and the start of the next.

Drivers who anticipate exceeding these limits due to traffic, loading delays, or weather must radio dispatch before the limit is reached so the load can be reassigned or a relief driver arranged. Driving past the limit without dispatch approval is treated as a serious handbook violation regardless of the reason.

4. Route Deviations and Communication

Routes are planned by dispatch and should be followed as assigned. Any deviation expected to add more than 15 minutes to the plan -- a road closure, a customer request, or traffic -- must be called in to dispatch before the deviation, not after.

Status updates (departed depot, arrived at stop, delivered, delayed) must be logged in the driver app in real time. This is the same status data that feeds the shipments table dispatchers and RouteMind query when a customer asks about a delivery.

5. Customer Interaction Standards

Drivers are the face of Portside Logistics at the customer's dock. Professional conduct is not optional: greet the receiving contact, confirm the shipment count matches the manifest, and obtain proof of delivery for every stop.

- Capture a signature or a delivery photo at every stop; at least one is mandatory.
- If a delivery is refused, note the reason code in the app and contact dispatch before leaving.
- Never leave a shipment unattended at a location with no authorized receiver.
- Escalate any dispute about shipment condition to dispatch rather than negotiating on-site.

6. Fuel Card and Expense Policy

Company fuel cards are for fuel, tolls, and approved parking only. Any other use must be pre-approved by the depot manager and supported by a receipt submitted within 5 business days.

7. Handbook Violations

Violations are logged by the depot manager and reviewed monthly. A first violation results in a documented warning; repeated violations within a rolling 12-month period can result in suspension of route assignments pending review.